🥗 Food & Nutrition: Reading

Health · Unit 2 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Food & Nutrition module (Nutrient Notes, Healthy Eating Plate, Labels, Sugar, Whole Foods, Meal Planning)

Name: _____

Fueling Your Body

Nutrients are the parts of food your body uses to live and grow. Macronutrients are needed in large amounts: carbohydrates (the main energy source), protein (builds and repairs muscle and helps the immune system) and fat (stores energy and builds cells). Water is also essential. Micronutrients, vitamins and minerals, are needed in small amounts, such as calcium for bones and iron for blood.

Not all fats are the same. Unsaturated fats, found in olive oil, nuts and fish, are healthier. Saturated fats, found in butter, cheese and red meat, should be limited. Trans fats, from partially hydrogenated oils, are the most harmful and should be avoided.

The Harvard Healthy Eating Plate is a guide for balanced meals. Half the plate is vegetables and fruit (potatoes do not count as vegetables because they raise blood sugar quickly). A quarter is whole grains such as oats, brown rice and whole wheat. A quarter is healthy protein such as fish, poultry, beans and nuts. Use healthy oils, drink water, tea or coffee, skip sugary drinks, and stay active.

A whole food has one ingredient, itself, and you can picture it growing. Processed foods are changed a lot and often have added sugar, salt and fat. Food travels from the farm to processing, then by truck, ship or plane to a store and finally to your plate. Cooking at home with whole ingredients is often healthier and cheaper.

Added sugar hides in many foods under more than 60 names. Too much is linked to heart disease, type 2 diabetes and liver disease. The World Health Organization recommends no more than about 26 grams (6 teaspoons) of added sugar a day; one teaspoon is about 4 grams. A 12-ounce soda has about 38 to 44 grams. The Nutrition Facts label shows the serving size, calories and added sugars, and the % Daily Value: 5% or less is low, and 20% or more is high.

Check your reading

1. Why should trans fats be avoided?

2. Why don't potatoes count as vegetables on the Healthy Eating Plate?

3. What two questions help you decide if a food is a whole food?